

DECODED EXPLAINED

12th September, 2026

Eyes on the road

Eyes on the road

Judicial fiat alone cannot prevent traffic fatalities

Despite hosting only 1% of the world's vehicular fleet, India accounts for around 11% of road traffic fatalities, due in some part to widespread non-compliance with wearing seat belts and helmets while driving. Post-crash investigations have often revealed victims being ejected from vehicles or suffering lethal secondary collisions against vehicles' interiors; children are also vulnerable due to the patchy use of child restraint systems and rear-seat belts. Recently, a Supreme Court Bench asked the Road Transport Ministry to consider a petition to reduce road traffic deaths by habituating the use of these measures. Actual policing is certainly wanting, including due to chronic shortages of traffic police cadres; there is also room to constrain manufacturers to install tamper-proof seat belt reminders and thwart modifications after purchase. The Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act 2019 instituted or scaffolded various mechanisms to prevent road traffic deaths whereas the national data so far have not presented evidence of improvement at the scale India needs.

However, in 2024, Road Transport Ministry data said that two-wheeler riders constituted 46.2% and pedestrians 20.6% of road deaths. Seat belts and child restraints only protect occupants of enclosed vehicles, so better enforcing their adoption will address the reasons underlying only one-third of the total mortality. In fact, speeding has been found to be the dominant recorded violation associated with fatalities, and a national strategy focused on mitigating opportunities for vehicles to accelerate to high speeds may yield greater gains. Second, neither the Union government nor State governments have systematically employed the 'Safe System' approach. While individual responsibility and the duty of care accruing to schools and similar institutions matter, governments are still expected to design roads assuming that not everyone will behave perfectly. Put differently, they need to reduce the probability as well as the severity of crashes, including by identifying and fixing accident-prone locations, setting up physical environments that compensate for human error, reducing children's exposure to two-wheeler traffic, and improving timely access to trauma care. Finally, India lacks a public culture that reinforces safe behaviour and deters unsafe behaviour. For India to reduce road mortality in a sustained manner, governments must treat safety through a combination of approaches that does not overstate the role of individual decisions. It is also commendable that the Court has referred the petition to the Centre, rather than assume an interventionist posture as it did in 2019, in a tacit acknowledgment that road safety has outgrown judicial fiat.

Eyes on the road

Statistics

Despite holding only 1% of world's vehicles, India accounts for around 11% of the world's accidents

Two wheeler riders constitute 46% of ride deaths and 20% are pedestrians

National highways, though only 2% of roads, accounted for 34.6% of deaths

Causes of road accidents in India

Seat belts and helmets : Victims being ejected from vehicles or suffering lethal secondary collision against vehicle interiors

Lack of child restraint systems and rear seatbelts

Lack of safe system approach in building roads

Overspeeding

Drunk Driving

Delay in Golden Hour Responses

Road Infrastructure : Black Spots

Vehicular Factors

Eyes on the road

- **Integrated Road Accident Database (iRAD)**: Technology-driven system to collect and analyse accident data for evidence-based policymaking.
- **Road Safety Audits (RSA)**: All National Highways (NHs) are mandated to have safety audits through third-party auditors/ experts at all stages, i.e., design, construction, operation, and maintenance.
- **Electronic Detailed Accident Report (e-DAR)**: The e-DAR project has been initiated to establish a central repository for reporting, managing, and analysing road accident data nationwide.
- **Good Samaritan Law**: It protects Good Samaritans from harassment in their actions to save the life of road accident victims.
- **Brasilia Declaration on Road Safety, 2015**: Under it, the countries plan to achieve SDG 3.6, i.e. to halve the number of global deaths and injuries from road traffic accidents by 2030. India signed it in 2015.
- **Awareness and Education**: Annual National Road Safety Month, inclusion of road safety in school curricula, and campaigns like Sadak Suraksha, Jeevan Raksha to promote behavioural change.
- **Decade of Action for Road Safety 2021-2030**: The UN General Assembly adopted the “Improving global road safety” resolution to prevent at least 50% of road traffic deaths and injuries by 2030.

India’s rising road accidents demand urgent action across the **four Es: engineering, enforcement, education, and emergency care**. Strengthening these pillars can reduce fatalities, protect livelihoods, and build a safer transport ecosystem.”

The BRICS bank - an alternative that wasn't

The BRICS bank — an alternative that wasn't

When India hosts the 18th BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13, 2026, under the banner of "Humanity First", the occasion will be draped in a familiar promise: that the bloc is building an alternative to the western-dominated global financial order. A new bank to rival the World Bank. A reserve fund to free countries from the International Monetary Fund. A path away from the dominance of the U.S. dollar. Seventeen years into the BRICS project, it is worth asking a blunt question: has any of this actually materialised?

The short answer is no; the reasons have less to do with intention than with structure. The BRICS countries, for all their rhetoric about reshaping the world, are deeply enmeshed in the very system that they claim to challenge. The institutions they built reflect that reality.

The same bank, different nameplate

The New Development Bank (NDB), launched in 2015, was BRICS's flagship creation. It was supposed to offer developing countries an alternative to the World Bank: loans without the political strings, governance without western dominance, financing in local currencies rather than dollars.

A decade later, half of the NDB's outstanding bonds are denominated in U.S. dollars, with the Chinese yuan making up most of the rest. The South African rand accounts for just one per cent. Local currency lending, which the bank's own leadership set as a target of 30% of its portfolio by the end of this year, sat at roughly 22% as of mid-2025. The NDB's first rupee-denominated bond was still in planning stages as late as September 2025, a full decade after the bank opened for business.

The NDB courts the same western credit-rating agencies (S&P, Fitch, Moody's) that the BRICS governments publicly criticise as biased against developing countries. And when those agencies' rules collided with bloc solidarity, the ratings won. In March 2022, days after Russia invaded Ukraine, the NDB froze all operations related to Russia, a founding member and 20% shareholder, to protect its own credit standing in New York. Russia has since relinquished its turn at the NDB's rotating presidency, extending the Brazilian incumbent's term to 2030. Whatever else this is, it is not an institution that operates outside western financial discipline.

The bank's total project approvals reached \$39 billion by the end of 2024. To put that in



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BRICS promised a new financial order through the New Development Bank, but the truth is that it remains deeply tied to the old one

perspective: the World Bank Group commits roughly \$100 billion every year. In a full decade of operation, the NDB has approved less than what its supposed rival disburses in six months. More importantly, the NDB co-finances projects with the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF) rather than offering a genuine alternative to them. The relationship is complementary, not competitive. That may be smart banking, but it is a far cry from the institution's founding rhetoric.

The safety net nobody uses

Alongside the NDB, the BRICS countries established the Contingent Reserve Arrangement in 2015: a \$100 billion pool of foreign exchange reserves meant to help member-countries weather financial crises without turning to the IMF. In principle, this was the most radical idea in the BRICS repertoire: a mechanism that could, over time, break the IMF's monopoly on emergency lending to the Global South.

In practice, the CRA has never been activated. Not once in a decade. And a closer look at the fine print reveals why. Any member-country that wants to draw more than 30% of its allotted share must first enter into a programme with the IMF. The escape hatch, in other words, leads right back to the institution that it was supposed to escape. The CRA has no permanent staff, no independent surveillance capacity, no research wing. It is, in effect, a promissory note dressed up as an institution; one that, by its own rules, cannot function independently of the very body it was created to rival.

If there is one idea that captures the public imagination about BRICS, it is de-dollarisation: the notion that the bloc will reduce the world's dependence on the U.S. dollar and shift global trade toward local currencies. Media coverage of every BRICS summit amplifies this promise. The reality is more modest than the headlines suggest.

The 126-point declaration issued at the Rio summit in July 2025 – the bloc's most comprehensive statement to date – does not contain the word "de-dollarisation" even once. Russian President Vladimir Putin himself stated in November 2024 that the bloc has "not sought to abandon the dollar". India opposes any move toward a common BRICS currency, fearing trade reprisals from Washington. South Africa considers the idea too risky. China prefers the gradual internationalisation of the yuan on its

own terms. When U.S. President Donald Trump threatened a 10% tariff surcharge on countries aligning with "anti-American" BRICS policies, the bloc offered no collective response. The episode was revealing: it showed how little it takes to deter the BRICS from even the appearance of challenging the dollar system.

Perhaps the most telling detail is what the BRICS actually ask for when they talk about reforming global finance. The declarations issued at both the Kazan summit in 2024 and the Rio summit in 2025 call for a "quota-based and adequately resourced" IMF. Read that carefully. The BRICS are not calling for the IMF to be replaced, restructured, or even fundamentally reformed. They are asking for a bigger say within it.

The problem is structural. The U.S. holds 16.49% of IMF voting rights, and all major decisions require an 85% supermajority. This gives Washington, and Washington alone, an effective veto over every significant decision that the fund makes. The BRICS countries know this.

They have known it for decades. And yet their official position is to ask for more chairs at a table whose rules guarantee that the outcome will always be decided by someone else.

What this tells us about BRICS

The bloc's defenders will point out that the NDB has financed real infrastructure, that its expansion to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates reflects a genuine desire among Global South countries for alternatives to western-led institutions, and that the frustration driving the BRICS agenda: with IMF conditionality, with dollar hegemony, with a financial system designed in 1944 by and for the industrialised West.

But the gap between the rhetoric and the record matters. The BRICS countries have not built an alternative financial architecture. They have built a set of institutions that operate within the existing one: lending in dollars, deferring to western rating agencies, designing safety nets that require IMF approval, and pledging loyalty to the very governance structures they publicly denounce. As India prepares to chair the bloc, the honest question is not whether BRICS can reform the global financial order. It is whether the governments that make up the bloc have any material interest in doing so, or whether, for their ruling establishments, a better seat at the existing table has always been the real objective.

The BRICS bank - an alternative that wasnt

New Development Bank

- The **New Development Bank (NDB)**, formerly known as the **BRICS Development Bank**, is a multilateral development bank established by **Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa (BRICS)**.
- The agreement for establishing the NDB was signed during the BRICS Summit held in Fortaleza, Brazil, on July 15, 2014 by the **Fortaleza Declaration**
- The bank became operational in 2015 and is headquartered in **Shanghai, China, with a regional office in Johannesburg and additional offices later opened in São Paulo and Moscow.**
- **Membership in NDB is open to any member of the United Nations.**
- **Members** : Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa
 - **New Members** : Bangladesh, UAE, Egypt, Algeria and Uzbekistan (**BUREAU**)
- **Share holding pattern**
 - Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa – each 18.72% (**Equal Shares**)
 - Egypt – 2.24%, Bangladesh – 1.76%, UAE – 1.04%, Algeria – 1.15% and Uzbekistan – 0.23%

The BRICS bank - an alternative that wasn't

Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA): It is a financial mechanism to protect against global liquidity pressures. CRA was established in 2015 to provide financial support to member countries that face balance of payments difficulties due to short-term liquidity pressures.

The legal basis for the Establishment was signed at Fortaleza, Brazil, in 2014. The CRA's total lending capacity is \$100 billion.

The BRICS bank - an alternative that wasnt

The 'Fortaleza Declaration', recently in the news, is related to the affairs of

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For Bihar flood problem, solution lies beyond

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BIHAR RECEIVED 27 per cent below-normal rainfall between June 1 and the first week of September. Even then, large parts of the state are under water. The Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Budhi Gandak, Punpun and Ghaghra have all risen above danger levels in different stretches. A combination of high upstream river flows and erratic weather — spells of heavy, localised rainfall amid an overall rainfall deficit — has contributed to the rivers spilling over their banks. The unusually high level of the Ganga also created a “backwater effect” in the Gandak and Punpun. Since these rivers drain into the Ganga, its high water level made it difficult for them to discharge their water. As a result, water backed up in the tributaries, adding to the flooding.

Since colonial times, flood-prone Bihar has tried to contain its rivers within defined channels through embankments. But embankments separate rivers from their floodplains, while continuous silt deposition raises riverbeds and reduces channel capacity. When an embankment breaches, the artificially contained water can rush into homes and fields. Bihar, therefore, needs to revisit the idea that higher or stronger embankments will *ipso facto* contain floods. Embankment maintenance must be accompanied by the restoration of drainage channels, protection of floodplains, better land-use planning, restoration of wetlands, and deployment of early-warning systems. The Ganga Basin River Management Plan, implemented for more than a decade, acknowledges these imperatives. But the persistent monsoon floods in Bihar underline that much needs to be done to give the river space to spread safely during periods of high discharge. Addressing Bihar’s concerns will require greater coordination between the riverine states on reservoir releases.

Bihar has long argued that the Farakka barrage and the India-Bangladesh Ganga Water Sharing Treaty have compounded the state’s river-management challenges. It contends that the barrage has altered the Ganga’s flow regime, affecting the movement and deposition of sediment load. The extent to which this contributes to floods in Bihar remains contested. Even so, renegotiation of the 1996 treaty, which expires in December, should take into account Bihar’s concerns over silt accumulation and the state’s river-management needs. The new arrangement needs to be informed by updated data on river flows and climate-change projections. In an era of erratic weather, states and countries sharing river basins should strengthen coordination to manage water flows and mitigate flood-related distress.

For Bihar flood problem, solution lies beyond

Causes

- 1. A tributary can flood because the main river is high: The unusually high level of the Ganga created a backwater effect in the Gandak and the Punpun, the condition where a high level in the receiving river obstructs the outflow of a river draining into it.**
- 2. The bed rises inside the confined channel: Continuous silt deposition raises the riverbed and reduces the channel's capacity to carry flow.**
- 3. A breach concentrates the damage: When an embankment breaches, artificially contained water rushes into homes and fields at a depth and force an unconfined flood would not produce.**

Thank You